

NOTE TO USERS

PREVIEW

This reproduction is the best copy available.

UMI[®]

PREVIEW

ABSTRACT

This dissertation examines the philosophical nature of confession and how every confession is also a disavowal. In Book X of the *Confessions*, Augustine asks about the source of forgetting and proposes that some logic underwrites its operations. I contend that one name for this logic is “disavowal,” a term Slavoj Žižek uses to mean consciously setting aside knowledge or holding two contradictory positions at the same time. For Žižek, disavowal operates like the fetish, in which the subject fashions a stand-in for the object of its real desires, which it can never fully attain. As an expression of desire, fetishistic disavowal functions to sustain what he calls “ideological fantasy,” a positive means of structuring and framing experience. Thus disavowal does not emanate from knowledge, but as an expression of desire.

In the same way confession, which is both a profession of belief and an attempt to adjudicate a wrong, is concerned not with knowledge but with desire. And yet, as Augustine attests, the confessing subject is opaque to itself and so can never fully know what or how to confess. Following Jacques Derrida’s *Circumfession*, I argue that desire and undecidability underwrite both disavowal and confession, revealing them not as dialectical and in need of resolution but rather as nonoppositional and productive phenomena.

The immediate application of my argument for theology is that, as an institution, theology is both problematized and enabled by disavowal. It is a problem for theology whenever concepts, words, habits and practices become fixed, hardened and taken to be “natural.” Conversely, disavowal enables theology by allowing it to “forget itself” and its previous formulations through what Derrida calls “iterability,” such that theology can continue its never-ending need for reconfiguration and reterritorialization. The aim, then, is not to overcome the structure of disavowal-confession, but rather to negotiate it in such a way that avows its inherent risks but also the abiding desires motivating it in the first place.

PREVIEW

**REMEMBERING TO FORGET:
THEOLOGICAL TROPOLOGIES OF
CONFESSION AND DISAVOWAL**

by

Neal E. Magee
B.A., Flagler College, 1991
M.Div., Princeton Theological Seminary, 1997
M.Phil., Syracuse University, 2001

A DISSERTATION

Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements
for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy in Religion
in the Graduate School of Syracuse University

December 2004

Approved


M. Gail Hamner

Date

12-14-04

UMI Number: 3160394

Copyright 2004 by
Magee, Neal E.

All rights reserved.

INFORMATION TO USERS

The quality of this reproduction is dependent upon the quality of the copy submitted. Broken or indistinct print, colored or poor quality illustrations and photographs, print bleed-through, substandard margins, and improper alignment can adversely affect reproduction.

In the unlikely event that the author did not send a complete manuscript and there are missing pages, these will be noted. Also, if unauthorized copyright material had to be removed, a note will indicate the deletion.

UMI[®]

UMI Microform 3160394

Copyright 2005 by ProQuest Information and Learning Company.
All rights reserved. This microform edition is protected against
unauthorized copying under Title 17, United States Code.

ProQuest Information and Learning Company
300 North Zeeb Road
P.O. Box 1346
Ann Arbor, MI 48106-1346

PREVIEW

© 2004 by Neal E. Magee
All rights reserved

**The Graduate School
Syracuse University**

We, the members of the Oral Examination Committee,
hereby register our concurrence that

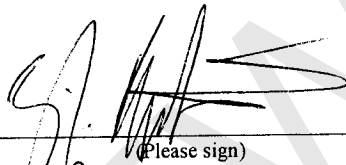
Neal E. Magee

satisfactorily defended his dissertation on

Wednesday, November 17, 2004

Examiners:

Zachary J. Braiterman


(Please sign)

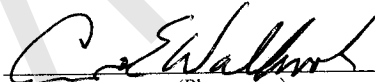
John D. Caputo


(Please sign)

Gregory Lambert

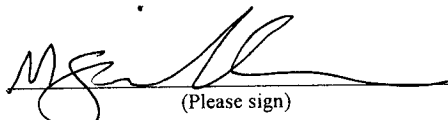
(Please sign)

Ernest E. Wallwork


(Please sign)

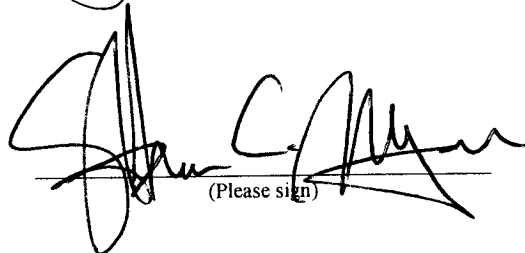
Advisor:

Martha Gail Hamner


(Please sign)

Oral Examination Chair:

Stephen C. Meyer


(Please sign)

In memory of three teachers:

Charles E. Winqvist
(1944-2002)

Donald H. Juel
(1942-2003)

Jacques Derrida
(1930-2004)

CONTENTS

<i>Tables & Illustrations</i>	viii
<i>Acknowledgments</i>	ix
<i>Abbreviations</i>	xi
Introduction – The Path to Disavowal	1
I. Argument and Objectives	4
II. Audience	7
III. On “Theology”	8
IV. Contribution	9
V. Strategies	11
Chapter One – The Question of Forgetting	15
I. Forgetfulness	15
II. Memory and Opacity	25
III. That Which I Hide from Myself	35
IV. False Confessions, Veracious Disavowals	39
V. Conclusion: A Problem and A Project	47
<i>Excursus One</i> – Marx & Heidegger: Structural Forgetting	58
Chapter Two – Sources for a Modern Concept of Forgetfulness:	
Nietzsche, Freud and Sartre	80
I. Introduction	80
II. Friedrich Nietzsche and <i>Vergeßlichkeit</i>	83
III. Sigmund Freud and <i>Verleugnung</i>	99
III. Jean-Paul Sartre and <i>Mauvaise Foi</i>	116
IV. Conclusion: Modern Conscious Forgetfulness	129
Chapter Three – Ideology and Forgetfulness:	
Peter Sloterdijk and Slavoj Žižek	133
I. The Momentum of Forgetting	133
II. Peter Sloterdijk and ‘Enlightened False Consciousness’	141
III. Slavoj Žižek and ‘The Fetishistic Logic of Disavowal’	159
IV. Conclusion: Concretizing Fantasy	193

<i>Excursus Two</i> – Second Nature, or, This is Not a Pipe	195
Chapter Four – Confession, Disavowal and Deconstruction: Jacques Derrida	208
I. Continual Attention	208
II. Covering Your Tracks – “How to Avoid Speaking”	214
III. The Confession Which Cuts – “Circumfession”	226
IV. Conclusion: Iterability, Theology and the Institution	246
<i>Excursus Three</i> – “The Style is the Man Himself”: Constructive Disavowal in Derrida’s <i>Glas</i>	256
Conclusion – A Theological Project of Disavowal	268
I. Estimating Disavowal	268
II. Perennial Risk	274
III. Divestment and Iteration	280
IV. The Impossibility of Overcoming	287
V. Infinite Negotiations	293
<i>Bibliography</i>	300
<i>Index</i>	319

TABLES & ILLUSTRATIONS

1. Table 1 – <i>Schematic differences between disavowal and confession</i>	24
2. René Magritte, <i>La Trahison des Images (Ceci n'est pas une pipe)</i> / “The Treachery of Images (This is not a pipe), circa 1928-29.	204
Oil on canvas. 25 7/16” X 37 1/16” (64.61cm X 94.13cm). Los Angeles County Museum of Art (no. 78.7), purchased with funds provided by the Mr. and Mrs. William Preston Harrison Collection.	
3. Table 2 – “ <i>Circumfession</i> ” and “ <i>Confession</i> ”: <i>Stems and Cognates</i>	229
4. Table 3 – <i>Iterability: Confession and Disavowal, Past and Future</i>	254
5. Table 4 – <i>Schematic contaminations of disavowal and confession</i>	292

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The period of time in which I researched and wrote this dissertation coincided with several important events. First, my family experienced the birth of our first child, which proved in so many ways to be an inspiring event and the beginning of a hopeful time in our lives. Second, this period coincided with the largest terrorist attacks on record in the United States, and so was marked by anxiety, fear, cynicism, and a heightened awareness of the political. Third was the death of my teacher Charles E. Winkquist, who had inspired many of my curiosities and the connections that interest me as a thinker. It is my hope that the hope, anxiety, and mourning within these events comes together productively here.

I would like to thank my teachers and mentors, most especially Professors Mattie Hart and Robin King at Flagler College, Pat Miller, Wentzel van Huyssteen and the late Don Juel at Princeton Theological Seminary, and David Miller and the late Charlie Winkquist of Syracuse University, all of whom had profound influences upon my own thought. My advisor for this project, Gail Hamner, has been a stunning mentor and colleague, never failing in critical observations, strategies, and enthusiasm. It was she who introduced me to the concept of Žižek's understanding of disavowal and consistently helped ground my work theologically and theoretically. She is also responsible for patiently and consistently raising the level of both my writing and my argument. I am thankful to Gregg Lambert for his ease, counsel, and guiding eye for both the large and

the small. He helped me see the importance of many overlooked aspects of the argument at hand. My sincerest appreciation also to Jack Caputo for his insights, encouragement, wit and help in the formulation of my work, particularly around the *Confessions* and the writings of Nietzsche, Heidegger, and Derrida.

Several readers have indulged me by looking over drafts of various chapters. I am grateful to Jeff Robbins, Ernie Wallwork and Patricia Cox Miller for their attentive reading and constructive feedback.

Additional thanks to Mme. Charly Herscovici in Brussels, President of the Succession Magritte, and Giselle Arteaga-Johnson and the Los Angeles County Museum of Art, for their kind permission to reproduce Magritte's lovely painting in Excursus Two.

Most of all I would like to thank my family, especially my wife Diana Brawley, for her incredible, abiding support and patience with this project, and for her years of hard work to see me through to its completion.

Neal E. Magee
Syracuse, New York
October 2004

ABBREVIATIONS

- AR* Mark C. Taylor, *About Religion: Economies of Faith in Virtual Culture* (Chicago: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1999).
- BN* Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness: A Phenomenological Essay on Ontology*, trans. H. E. Barnes (New York: Washington Square, 1956).
- BT* Martin Heidegger, *Being and Time*, trans. J. Stambaugh (Albany: SUNY Press, 1996).
- CCR* Peter Sloterdijk, *Critique of Cynical Reason*, trans. M. Elred (Minneapolis: Univ. of Minnesota Press, 1987).
- Circ.* Jacques Derrida, "Circumfession: Fifty-nine Periods and Periphrases written in a sort of internal margin, between Geoffrey Bennington's book and work in preparation (January 1989–April 1990)," G. Bennington and Jacques Derrida, *Jacques Derrida*, trans. G. Bennington (Chicago: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1993).
- CIS* Richard Rorty, *Contingency, irony, and solidarity* (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1996).
- Conf.* Augustine, *The Confessions*, trans. H. Chadwick (New York: Oxford Univ. Press, 1991).
- DB* Geoffrey Bennington, "Derridabase," G. Bennington and Jacques Derrida, *Jacques Derrida* (Chicago: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1993).
- DN* John D. Caputo, editor. *Deconstruction in a Nutshell: A Conversation with Jacques Derrida* (New York: Fordham University Press, 1997).
- FA* Slavoj Žižek, *The Fragile Absolute* (London: Verso, 2000).
- Glas* Jacques Derrida, *Glas*, trans. R. Rand and J. Leavey, Jr. (Lincoln: Univ. of Nebraska Press, 1986).
- HTAS* Jacques Derrida, "How to Avoid Speaking: Denials," *Derrida and Negative Theology*, trans. K. Frieden (Albany: SUNY Press, 1992): 73–142.
- JAAR* *The Journal of the American Academy of Religion*.
- JCRT* *The Journal for Cultural and Religious Theory*.
- PD* Slavoj Žižek, *The Puppet and the Dwarf* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2003).
- PF* Slavoj Žižek, *The Plague of Fantasies* (London: Verso, 1997).
- PT* John D. Caputo, *The Prayers and Tears of Jacques Derrida: Religion*

- without Religion* (Bloomington: Univ. of Indiana Press, 1997).
- SEC* Jacques Derrida, "Signature Event Context," trans. S. Weber and J. Mehlman, *Glyph 1* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins Univ. Press, 1977): 172-97.
- SOI* Slavoj Žižek, *The Sublime Object of Ideology* (London: Verso, 1989).
- TR* Jacques Derrida, "Typewriter Ribbon: Limited Ink (2)," *Without Alibi*, trans. P. Kamuf (Stanford: Stanford Univ. Press, 2002): 71-160.
- UM* Friedrich Nietzsche, *Untimely Meditations*, trans. R.J. Hollingdale (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1997).
- UWC* Jacques Derrida, "The University Without Condition," *Without Alibi*, trans. P. Kamuf (Stanford: Stanford Univ. Press, 2002): 202-37.
- V* Jacques Derrida, *Voyous: Deux essais sur la raison* (Paris: Galilée, 2003).
- WDR* Slavoj Žižek, *Welcome to the Desert of the Real* (London: Verso, 2002).
- WA* Jacques Derrida, *Without Alibi*, trans. P. Kamuf (Stanford: Stanford Univ. Press, 2002).

Augustine. See *Conf*.

Bennington, Geoffrey. See *DB*.

Caputo, John D. See *DN*, *PT*.

Derrida, Jacques. See *Circ.*, *Glas*, *HTAS*, *SEC*, *TR*, *UWC*, *V*, *WA*.

Heidegger, Martin. See *BT*.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. See *UM*.

Rorty, Richard. See *CIS*.

Sartre, Jean-Paul. See *BN*.

Sloterdijk, Peter. See *CCR*.

Taylor, Mark C. See *AR*.

Žižek, Slavoj. See *FA*, *PD*, *PF*, *SOI*, *WDR*.

Custom, especially that which dates from childhood, takes on the force of nature and as a result the things with which the mind has been imbued from childhood take such firm root that it is as if they were naturally known of themselves.

—Thomas Aquinas

*Dès qu'il est saisi par l'écriture,
le concept est cuit.*

As soon as it is seized by writing,
the concept is done for.

—Jacques Derrida

PREVIEW

INTRODUCTION

THE PATH TO DISAVOWAL

“Let us work without theorizing,” said Martin; “’tis the only way to make life endurable.”

The whole small fraternity entered into this praiseworthy plan, and each started to make use of his talents. The little farm yielded well. Cunegonde was indeed very ugly, but she became an excellent pastry cook; Paquette embroidered; the old woman took care of the linen. Even Friar Giroflée performed some service; he was a very good carpenter and even became a man of honor; and Pangloss sometimes said to Candide: “All events are linked up in this best of all possible worlds; for, if you had not been expelled from the noble castle, by hard kicks in your backside for love of Mademoiselle Cunegonde, if you had not been clapped into the Inquisition, if you had not wandered about America on foot, if you had not stuck your sword in the Baron, if you had not lost all your sheep from the land of Eldorado, you would not be eating candied citrons and pistachios here.”

“’Tis well said,” replied Candide, “but we must cultivate our gardens.”

—Voltaire, *Candide*

The linguist Geoff Nunberg observes that as our culture changes, so too our vocabulary evolves to mark those changes. In some cases, we must go back and modify older terms in order to keep up. Linguists call these *retronyms*, words that distinguish between old ideas or practices and new ones. Retronyms are the names for distinctions that at one time were unnecessary.¹ Today, for instance, we find ourselves using phrases like “silent movie,” “manual transmission,” “organic farm,” “acoustic guitar,” and “heterosexual marriage.” Not so long ago these phrases could have left their modifiers at

¹ Geoffrey Nunberg, *Going Nocular* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2004), 239.

home, with just the noun doing all the work. But change announces itself and, while language and culture are savvy enough to keep up, it is easy to forget the reasons that brought about these new terms.

For example, while the terms “heterosexual marriage” and “homosexual marriage” mark a change by adding new and distinctive modifiers, their conceptual history will always be quickly forgotten even if their practical consequences will be enjoyed. That is, these concepts do not necessarily convey that there once was a time when “marriage” was not so diversified and really only meant the former. In addition, these new phrases do not disclose the many cultural assumptions (taken to be “natural” reasoning) about what “marriage” entails and the political struggle over this word. Regardless of how one feels about this turn of events, this linguistic progression marks the departure of an older way of thinking and leaves telling this history to someone else.

Like the case of retronyms, this sort of forgetting also occurs in the world of ideas. Take, for example, contemporary environmentalism. Environmentalists perceive that theirs is a cause *for* nature and its preservation, and *against* heartless businesses that presumably will exploit natural resources as far as they are allowed. Nevertheless, the environmentalist movement forgets the economic and social changes that gave rise to its emergence. Protecting the environment, as it is understood today, is not a natural stance; it has only existed as an impulse from the industrial era forward. Therefore, while claiming to reject the terms of capitalism, environmentalism is intractably defined by its parameters. (Even if it is based on a certain nostalgia for a pre-industrialized nature.) In its desire to shrug off all things ecologically destructive, environmentalism has forgotten that it too is born of modern industrial capitalism. Recognizing this forgetfulness should

thus be important in understanding this movement.

These examples are good linguistic ways of introducing the force of “disavowal” as I intend it in this dissertation. Disavowal—the conscious, volitional setting aside of a fact, problem or condition—as a critical concept, plays a central function in the forgetfulness I describe above. I use this term as a trope by which to gather a cluster of closely related themes: active forgetfulness, self-deception, denial, false consciousness, bad faith, and cynicism.² While disavowal in common usage has the force of a strong denial, rejection or repudiation of what one has formerly held, this dissertation proposes that the turning point of disavowal is found not in epistemology (knowledge is removed from the equation in disavowal) but rather in the *motivating desire* for such denial.

One would expect that theological and philosophical concepts also carry this sort of forgotten baggage. “Monotheism,” e.g., as a theological idea can only be understood against the alternative of polytheism; Trinitarian Christian doctrine reflects a tension between the desire to unify theories of the nature of God while still acknowledging ambiguity and difference. Both doctrines avow themselves by forgetting their historical and contingent construction. In both cases, what ends up happening is that concepts which once served as intellectual scaffolding are now taken as though they were natural and obvious. Disavowal makes this shift towards concretizing possible. While such

² “Disavowal,” while it has its roots in Freud (and developed further by Jacques Lacan and Slavoj Žižek), should *not* be taken as the literal translation of a particular term (i.e. Freud’s “*Verleugnung*”), but rather as a trope for the manifold problem of conscious forgetting with which this study is concerned. Adopting this particular tropology from Žižek’s interventions in *The Sublime Object of Ideology* and elsewhere, disavowal indicates a rubric or genealogy of the question of conscious forgetting that draws upon concepts from psychoanalysis, philosophy, religion, politics, economy and ideology critique. I acknowledge the historical and discursive distinctions between such concepts and disciplines, but ask the reader to allow for their coming together here. A fuller definition of disavowal will emerge throughout this study, but is laid out in closest detail in Chapter Three, where Žižek relates it symbolically to Freud’s understanding of the fetish. Care is necessary, however, in using this term and the “depth” to which it cuts into memory, whether deep or superficial. Unless specifically noted, use of the term “forgetfulness” (by which I intend conscious or deliberate forgetfulness) will also serve as a cognate to disavowal.

forgetting can at times be problematic, at other times it is absolutely vital and energetic. Thus the concept of disavowal is, for my purposes, a way of entry into the dynamic of forgetting (whether problematic or constructive), as well as a way of examining the impulses behind such forgetfulness.

I. Argument and Objectives

I will approach this problem particularly as it concerns one central theological notion: “confession.” My use of confession in this project is to engage it with disavowal in such a way that does not simply conflate the terms but rather broadens and complexifies each. The confessor confesses in order to put something to rest by offering it over to another. The act of disavowal, likewise, divulges a secret desire to ameliorate the pressures and traumas of reality. In either case, confession and disavowal function by choice to serve very similar ends. They each are a part of the other: disavowals confess (avow) while confessions deny (disavow). The Möbius strip of confession and disavowal flows naturally from one into the other, no matter how you cut it.

My concern in approaching disavowal and confession is to limit the pretensions of theology while attempting to foster its future growth. To these ends, I wish to work toward what Emmanuel Levinas calls a “*maturity and patience for insoluble problems*.”³ Too often insolubility leads to an effort for hard and fast answers. Such maturity and patience may well give rise to a new genre of theological and religious discourse. The examination of disavowal and its relationship to confession below is, at its heart, an

³ Emmanuel Levinas, *Alterity and Transcendence*, trans. Michael B. Smith (New York: Columbia Univ. Press, 1999), 87.

attempt to delineate the limits of theological critique. This applies to external critiques of theology (the ways in which theology has been disavowed and confessed) as well as theological reflection itself (the ways in which theology disavows and confesses).

Of particular concern to me is how theology considers certain goals and ideas to be “natural” and whether disavowal might actually assist in conferring that status. Does disavowal, which is always motivated by desire, become an overlooked means of granting the work of theology a certain authority and legitimacy? My focus then is how the notion of “theology”—like the retronym—masks over changes and assumptions that have deliberately been forgotten. In the case of theology, I argue that it has disavowed the possibility of openness and contingency as a discourse by choosing to articulate itself in terms of certitude and closure. Especially in its dogmatic and systematic formulations, theology acts as though its task is certainty or the production of theological Truth, and thus closes off new possibilities with the greatest of conservative impulses and seeking to quell difference. Such is the case of fundamentalism, which deploys a hermeneutics of supposedly “transparent” readings of what a sacred text really says, as well as an aggressive praxis in defense of its ideological and theological position.

Nevertheless, disavowal is not merely “out there,” an ailment of weak or dim thought. All theology is constrained in this regard, and no articulation of theology escapes the logic of disavowal; while its content always remains a matter of choice, its eventuality can be understood as quasi-structural. Therefore even non-fundamentalist, non-systematic and non-dogmatic theologies fall into its habits. But this is not all bad. As I argue in the conclusion, and drawing from Nietzsche, Žižek, and Derrida, a study of disavowal has something positive to offer the theological venture. I argue for at least

three positive aspects to such a project:

1. *An analysis of disavowal aids the discipline of theology by probing its aims and limits.* It asks about the limits of theology's ability to critique, and denudes its objectives to their most essential forms. A project of disavowal, in this sense, requires theology to always-already hold open the question of its purpose—Why do theology? It is not that this question itself is unanswerable, but that such answers are at best provisional and iterable. By its very nature, theology must remain open to what seems impossible. In our ability to actively forget and disavow the former aims of theology we may begin to render its newer articulations.

2. *Disavowal illuminates the double nature of institutions including theology.* Institutions, the great conservative forces for founding concepts and keeping boundaries secure, at some point must always rely on disavowal in order to avoid the decay of passing time. Every institution must, at some point, “forget itself” in order to transcend itself. A study of disavowal for the institution of theology strives to recognize this double nature of the institution and especially to recognize it as another constructive limit.

3. *Disavowal operates according to desire, which can be recognized in the fetish.* By examining fetishism, theology has something to learn about its own desires. Theological fetishes can arise in the form of sacred texts, hermeneutics, rites (baptism, eucharist, statements of faith, confessions), doctrine and dogmatic formulations (Trinity, monotheism), and the self-narrative of theology itself (how theologians describe the aims of theology). These are all properly acts of faith—undertaken with no assurances of verification, but with a certain hope and faithfulness—and yet all too often they are taken as though they are epistemologically certain.

II. Audience

For whom am I writing? The primary cultural force in North America and Europe is secular, and so on the one hand this is written to those within those regions who have been raised and taught to rely on things outside the theological framework. It is an interesting challenge, and a delight, to bring the secular to bear on how one reads theology, and many of my students who have little or no familiarity with things religious or theological continually raise important questions and remind me of certain vocabularies, histories, and institutions which can no longer be taken for granted in the West. To have this sort of student grappling with theology, albeit in indirect ways, introduces the idea that it is not such a foreign tongue to begin with, and that perhaps while cultural institutions and priorities have shifted, a certain continuity is still at work. Perhaps my secular reader would be the sort who is concerned with questions of meaning and value, who still believes in the usefulness of the language of “depth,” and who appreciates thinking about things with no settled or clean outcome.

On the other hand, as one raised in the Christian church and having received formal training in theology, biblical and religious studies, I write for my theologically-minded colleagues and friends with whom I share a certain history. This academically theological audience to whom I write shares my appreciation for certain texts, traditions, and figures which still seem worthy of our time and efforts, despite their dissembling by scholars, ambiguities, and inner contradictions. By exploring the term “disavowal,” which is ripe with philosophical, psychoanalytical, ethical and religious significance, I would hope to broaden, complexify, and disturb their thought. My aim is to encourage theological reflection unafraid of engaging other quite different disciplines: film,